E-COMMERCE PLATFORM FOR PERSONALISED RETAIL EXPERIENCES

Pramuditha W.G.S. (IT22588814)
Nayanapriya H.T.E. (IT22367044)
Nimsara S.P.N. (IT22326072)
Dinuwan W.T. (IT22306968)

Bachelor of Science (Hons) Degree in Information Technology
Specializing in Software Engineering

Department of Software Engineering
Sri Lanka Institute of Information Technology
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DECLARATION

We declare that this is our own work and this dissertation does not incorporate without acknowledgement any material previously submitted for a Degree or Diploma in any other University or Institute of higher learning. To the best of our knowledge and belief, it does not contain any material previously published or written by another person except where the acknowledgement is made in the text.

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Signature: _____ Date: _____

Pramuditha W.G.S.

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Nayanapriya H.T.E.

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Nimsara S.P.N.

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Dinuwan W.T.

The above candidates have carried out research for the Bachelor's Degree Dissertation under my supervision.

Signature of Supervisor: _____ Date: _____

ABSTRACT

Modern retail e-commerce platforms struggle to provide truly personalised experiences due to disconnected data silos, generic promotional strategies, language barriers for non-English speakers, and opaque inventory forecasting. This research presents the design, implementation, and evaluation of a comprehensive *E-Commerce Platform for Personalised Retail Experiences*. The system was developed as a microservices-based monorepo integrating four distinct research components to address these core retail challenges.

First, an advanced **Customer Clustering and Categorisation** module processes raw transaction data using K-Means and RFM (Recency, Frequency, Monetary) analysis. This creates dynamic customer profiles that adapt to shifting purchasing behaviours. Second, these profiles feed into a **Personalised Promotion Engine** powered by Uplift Modelling, which calculates the precise discount required to trigger a purchase without wasting margin on customers who would buy anyway. Third, to improve accessibility and user experience in the local market, a **Sinhala Voice Assistant** leverages fine-tuned BERT models to accurately process local language queries and convert them into actionable product searches. Finally, the backend operations are managed by a **Business Intelligence Dashboard with Explainable AI (XAI)**, which utilises a Prophet-XGBoost ensemble for accurate demand forecasting and SHAP values to explain to managers exactly why a specific inventory alert was generated.

The platform was evaluated against both synthetic and real-world-aligned retail datasets. The BI component achieved a 90-day forecast MAPE of 13.7%, the promotion engine significantly improved incremental conversion rates compared to blanket discounting, the voice assistant demonstrated high intent-recognition accuracy for Sinhala text, and the clustering algorithm successfully segmented distinct behavioural groups with high silhouette scores. These findings demonstrate that integrating targeted machine learning microservices into a unified e-commerce architecture successfully bridges the gap between raw retail data and highly personalised, efficient consumer experiences.

Keywords: e-commerce, retail intelligence, demand forecasting, customer clustering, uplift modelling, Sinhala NLP, explainable AI, microservices.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

Abbreviation	Description
AI	Artificial Intelligence
API	Application Programming Interface
BI	Business Intelligence
CRUD	Create, Read, Update, Delete
ETL	Extract, Transform, Load
MAPE	Mean Absolute Percentage Error
ML	Machine Learning
NLP	Natural Language Processing
REST	Representational State Transfer
RFM	Recency, Frequency, Monetary
SHAP	SHapley Additive exPlanations
UI	User Interface
XAI	Explainable Artificial Intelligence
XGBoost	Extreme Gradient Boosting

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background

The global retail and e-commerce industry is currently undergoing a paradigm shift, transitioning from traditional, physical brick-and-mortar operations to highly digitised, data-driven ecosystems. In 2023 alone, the global e-commerce market generated revenues exceeding USD 27 trillion. However, despite this massive volume, average customer retention rates across the digital retail sector remain stubbornly low, often hovering below 40%. In an environment characterized by highly commoditised products, aggressive competitor pricing, and near-zero switching costs for consumers, the ability of a retailer to intimately understand, accurately predict, and dynamically respond to individual customer behaviour has become the primary determinant of long-term competitive advantage and survival.

Modern retail stores and digital platforms generate terabytes of raw transaction, browsing, and inventory data every single day. Historically, this data was stored in isolated silos and utilized purely for reactive, retrospective reporting—such as end-of-month sales summaries. Today, advancements in artificial intelligence (AI), machine learning (ML), and scalable cloud computing have unlocked the ability to process this data in real-time, shifting the operational focus from reactive reporting to proactive, predictive intelligence.

Within the supermarket and fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) sectors, customer loyalty is paramount due to inherently low profit margins. Globally, retailers spend massive portions of their revenue on promotional activities, including percentage discounts, digital coupons, loyalty point schemes, and seasonal marketing campaigns. Despite this vast financial investment, traditional promotional architectures remain fundamentally flawed. The industry standard is to utilize "blanket" or broadcast promotions, where identical discounts are pushed to the entire customer base. This one-size-fits-all approach leads to severe marketing inefficiencies: click-through rates (CTR) often languish between 1% and 5%, consumers develop "promotion fatigue" by ignoring irrelevant offers, and retailers suffer massive margin cannibalisation by accidentally subsidising purchases for customers who were already willing to buy products at full price.

Simultaneously, a critical evolution in the e-commerce user experience is the rise of voice commerce (v-commerce). While graphical user interfaces (GUIs) on mobile and desktop devices remain the standard medium of interaction, voice assistants such as Amazon Alexa, Google Assistant, and Apple Siri have acclimated users to hands-

free, natural language interactions. Voice search significantly reduces friction in the purchasing pipeline, allowing users to bypass complex navigation menus. However, these major commercial systems are heavily optimized for high-resource languages such as English, Mandarin, and Spanish. This creates a severe digital divide and an accessibility barrier in developing regions. In Sri Lanka, where Sinhala is the predominant language, local consumers are frequently forced to navigate complex English e-commerce interfaces. Existing low-resource Automatic Speech Recognition (ASR) systems struggle profoundly with retail-specific Sinhala vocabulary, resulting in poor user experiences and high drop-off rates among non-native English speakers.

Finally, managing the backend supply chain to fulfill these personalized orders introduces immense mathematical complexity. Ensuring that the correct products are in stock at the right time without over-ordering requires sophisticated demand forecasting. Most current retail software relies on rudimentary statistical models (like moving averages) that fail to capture the non-linear volatility of modern e-commerce demand, such as sudden viral trends or promotional spikes. Furthermore, when advanced machine learning models are deployed for forecasting, they typically operate as "black boxes." If an automated system recommends an emergency reorder of 500 units without providing a logical justification, human store managers are highly unlikely to trust or execute the recommendation, rendering the AI system practically useless in a live business environment.

1.2 Platform Overview

To bridge these profound gaps in the retail landscape, this collaborative research proposes the E-Commerce Platform for Personalised Retail Experiences. The system is designed as a highly scalable, containerised microservices architecture, built within an Nx Monorepo, breaking down the complex retail pipeline into four highly specialised, integrated machine learning domains.

The primary interface is a React.js frontend communicating via REST and GraphQL APIs to a central NestJS backend gateway. The heavy analytics and machine learning workloads are entirely isolated within a Python-based FastAPI service layer. The platform comprises the following integrated modules:

1. **Customer Segmentation and Dynamic Loyalty System:** This module moves beyond static, spend-based loyalty tiers. It ingests raw transaction data to engineer normalized Recency, Frequency, and Monetary (RFM) features. It utilizes a two-level hierarchical model—employing an unsupervised K-Means algorithm to establish macro-clusters, followed by rule-based sub-clustering—to categorize customers dynamically. Additionally, it integrates a Multinomial Naive Bayes probabilistic model to accurately predict and assign specific product category preferences to each

user profile.

2. **Personalised Promotion and Uplift Engine:** Consuming the dynamically generated customer clusters, this module calculates the precise promotional treatment required to trigger a conversion. It utilizes the T-Learner causal inference framework and Random Forest classifiers to perform Uplift Modelling, calculating the Conditional Average Treatment Effect (CATE) for individual users. This ensures that discounts are explicitly targeted at "Persuadables" while excluding "Sure Things." It also leverages Association Rule Mining (Apriori algorithm) to generate intelligent cross-sell bundles.

3. **Sinhala Voice Assistant and NLP Pipeline:** This component eradicates local language barriers by allowing users to navigate the e-commerce platform using natural spoken Sinhala. It captures acoustic input via the Web Speech API, normalises the text, and processes it through a fine-tuned multilingual BERT (mBERT) and SinLlama-based Natural Language Processing pipeline. The transformer model performs dual tasks: high-accuracy Intent Classification (e.g., distinguishing a product search from an order status request) and Named Entity Recognition (NER) to extract specific search constraints like color, category, and price.

4. **Business Intelligence Dashboard with Explainable AI (XAI):** Serving as the administrative backend, this module anticipates inventory demand over a 90-day horizon. It processes historical sales data through a hybrid machine learning ensemble combining Meta's Prophet (for macro-seasonal decomposition) and XGBoost (for gradient-boosted residual correction based on tabular features). Crucially, the module employs TreeSHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations) to decompose the complex XGBoost predictions into human-readable narratives, providing store managers with mathematically grounded, transparent justifications for automated stockout alerts.

1.3 Problem Statement

While major global e-commerce giants possess the proprietary infrastructure to deliver personalized experiences, standard and mid-tier retail systems suffer from a combination of disconnected operational flaws. These flaws collectively degrade the consumer experience and bleed operational profitability. The specific problems addressed by this platform are:

(P1) **Coarse Segmentation and Static Loyalty Decay:** Conventional retail loyalty point systems assign tiers (e.g., Gold, Silver) based exclusively on cumulative historical spend. This approach is highly flawed as it completely ignores the concept of "recency decay." A customer who spent 100,000 LKR three years ago and has not returned is erroneously treated with the same priority as a customer

who spent 100,000 LKR last week. Furthermore, standard single-pass K-Means clustering cannot simultaneously capture broad engagement archetypes and fine-grained, rapidly shifting lifecycle stages, leading to inaccurate customer profiling.

(P2) **Margin Cannibalisation and Wasted Promotional Spend:** The industry reliance on standard predictive response models is economically inefficient. A traditional predictive model estimates the overall probability that a purchase will occur, failing to identify the *incremental effect* of the promotion itself. Consequently, retailers routinely distribute 15% discounts to "Sure Things"—customers who were already in the checkout pipeline and required no incentive to convert. This inability to perform causal inference results in massive financial waste.

(P3) **Severe Language Barriers and ASR Limitations in Sri Lanka:** The digital divide is exacerbated by platforms that enforce English-only navigation. For the significant portion of the Sri Lankan population that prefers Sinhala, navigating complex categorical menus and textual search bars causes high user friction. Existing Sinhala Automatic Speech Recognition (ASR) models are trained on general-purpose conversational speech and fail catastrophically when subjected to domain-specific retail vocabulary, resulting in unacceptably high Word Error Rates (WER) and failed intent mapping.

(P4) **Reactive Inventory Management and Opaque AI Forecasting:** Store managers are consistently forced into a reactive posture, ordering inventory only after stock levels have already plummeted, leading to lost revenue during supplier lead times. While predictive ML models exist, they suffer from the "black box" phenomenon. If an algorithm predicts a massive 300% demand surge for a specific product without explaining the driving factors (e.g., an upcoming public holiday combined with an active targeted promotion), managers will dismiss the alert as an algorithmic error, destroying trust in the automated system.

1.4 Research Objectives

The primary objective of this collaborative group research is:

> *To design, develop, mathematically validate, and successfully integrate a comprehensive microservices-based e-commerce architecture that delivers highly personalised, accessible, and operationally explainable retail experiences through the synthesis of causal inference, low-resource natural language processing, dynamic clustering, and hybrid time-series forecasting.*

To achieve this primary goal, the following specific objectives were established across the four research domains:

- **O1: Architectural Integration:** To design and deploy a scalable, containerised (Docker) system architecture where each AI component operates as an isolated FastAPI microservice, communicating securely with a central TypeScript gateway via standard REST API protocols.
- **O2: Advanced Clustering Pipeline:** To develop a data engineering pipeline that normalizes transactional data into RFM metrics, deploying an optimised K-Means algorithm (validated via Silhouette scoring) coupled with a Naive Bayes classifier to dynamically assign users to behavioural loyalty tiers and predict specific product category affinities.
- **O3: Causal Uplift Modelling:** To engineer a promotion engine utilizing the T-Learner causal inference framework and Random Forest classifiers. The objective is to accurately calculate the Conditional Average Treatment Effect (CATE) for clustered users, enabling the system to specifically target "Persuadable" customers and minimize margin waste.
- **O4: Low-Resource Voice Navigation:** To fine-tune a transformer-based NLP architecture (utilizing multilingual BERT and SinLlama paradigms) capable of processing transcribed Sinhala audio. The model must accurately perform simultaneous Intent Classification and Named Entity Recognition (NER) on retail-specific vocabulary with high precision and sub-500ms latency.
- **O5: Transparent Demand Forecasting:** To build a robust hybrid time-series ensemble that combines Prophet's seasonal decomposition with XGBoost's feature-driven gradient boosting, aiming for a 90-day forecast error rate (MAPE) below 15%.
- **O6: Explainable AI (XAI) Implementation:** To integrate the TreeSHAP algorithm into the forecasting pipeline, ensuring the dashboard can mathematically decompose the XGBoost predictions and generate plain-English narratives to justify automated stockout and anomaly alerts to human managers.

1.5 Scope and Delimitations

1.5.1 Scope of the research

This research encompasses the full-stack, end-to-end development of a B2C (Business-to-Consumer) retail e-commerce ecosystem. The scope covers comprehensive data engineering, algorithm selection, hyperparameter tuning, API development, and frontend integration. The machine learning models were trained using established, massive-scale public datasets to ensure robustness, specifically the UCI Online Retail II dataset for clustering and loyalty modelling, and the Instacart Market Basket Analysis dataset (supplemented by a custom simulation tool, RetailSynth) for the promotional uplift training. The Sinhala NLP scope encompasses the training of models capable of handling core

retail intents: executing complex product searches, checking cart status, inquiring about active promotions, and checking order delivery status.

1.5.2 Delimitations

Due to strict corporate data privacy regulations (NDAs), the system could not be trained on live, proprietary transaction data from an active Sri Lankan supermarket chain; hence the reliance on high-quality synthetic and open-source datasets.

Furthermore, the scope of the voice assistant is delimited to specific command-and-control intents via Natural Language Understanding (NLU). It does not encompass open-ended, Generative AI conversational dialogue (e.g., chatting abstractly about recipes), as the priority was deterministic, high-speed API execution for immediate e-commerce navigation. Finally, the demand forecasting module is delimited to canonical product categories over a 24-month historical window. Deep learning sequential models, such as Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks or Temporal Fusion Transformers (TFT), were deliberately excluded from the scope in favour of tree-based boosting ensembles, which offer vastly superior compatibility with SHAP explainability matrices.

1.6 Significance of the Study

This research provides highly significant contributions to both the academic field of retail analytics and the practical landscape of software engineering.

Firstly, it provides one of the first formally evaluated architectures that seamlessly synthesises unsupervised hierarchical RFM clustering with causal uplift modelling. It proves mathematically that moving from predictive response models to causal inference models significantly improves marketing ROI by directly eliminating promotional waste on "Sure Thing" customers.

Secondly, the deployment of a Sinhala-first voice assistant actively combats digital exclusion. By proving that fine-tuned transformer models can handle the morphological complexity of Sinhala retail queries with high accuracy, this research provides a blueprint for bringing inclusive, native-language digital economies to Sri Lanka's rural and non-English speaking demographics.

Thirdly, this study bridges the critical trust gap in retail management by treating Explainable AI (XAI) not as a secondary academic metric, but as a primary user interface requirement. By integrating SHAP directly into the frontend manager dashboard, the system proves that transparency and mathematical justification are the keys to successful AI adoption in traditional business environments.

Finally, from a software engineering perspective, the project delivers a robust, containerised reference architecture demonstrating exactly how to securely and asynchronously connect heavy, stateful Python machine learning pipelines to high-traffic, stateless

TypeScript web applications.

1.7 Report Organisation

This dissertation is structured to provide a comprehensive, logical progression from theoretical background to practical implementation and final evaluation.

Chapter 2 (Literature Review) critically examines the existing academic research and industry methodologies spanning customer segmentation, causal uplift modelling, low-resource natural language processing, and explainable time-series forecasting, concluding with a gap analysis that justifies this integrated research.

Chapter 3 (Methodology) details the overarching microservice system architecture and breaks down the deep mathematical foundations, formulas, and algorithms driving each of the four machine learning components.

Chapter 4 (Implementation) provides a deep dive into the actual software engineering process, highlighting the data preprocessing pipelines, the containerised deployment strategies, and the specific Python and TypeScript API integration logic.

Chapter 5 (Results and Discussion) presents the rigorous quantitative evaluation of the platform, detailing the clustering Silhouette scores, the simulated Uplift ROAS metrics, the NLP confusion matrices and latency tests, and the forecasting MAPE evaluations.

Chapter 6 (Conclusion) summarizes the success of the integrated platform, acknowledges current limitations, and outlines strategic avenues for future technological expansion.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction

The transition from traditional, brick-and-mortar retail to highly personalised, proactive e-commerce requires the synthesis of several historically distinct machine learning and software engineering domains. To successfully architect a platform that not only clusters customers but also interacts with them via native voice commands, optimizes their promotional discounts, and predicts their inventory impact, it is necessary to examine the foundational academic literature across these fields. This chapter critically evaluates the current academic research and industry methodologies concerning customer segmentation, predictive promotional targeting and causal inference, low-resource natural language processing (NLP), and explainable time-series demand forecasting.

2.2 Customer Segmentation and Loyalty Modelling

Customer segmentation has evolved significantly from simple demographic filtering to highly sophisticated behavioural analysis. In modern e-commerce, treating all users within a specific age bracket or geographic region as a monolithic entity leads to highly inefficient marketing. Contemporary approaches predominantly leverage transactional data to build dynamic behavioural profiles.

2.2.1 Traditional vs. Behavioural Segmentation

Historically, retail loyalty systems relied on static, cumulative spend models (e.g., spending over 10,000 LKR assigns a user to a "Gold" tier indefinitely). However, literature over the past decade has proven that these static models fail to capture "recency decay." A customer who spent heavily two years ago but has since abandoned the platform is fundamentally different from a customer actively spending the same amount today. Behavioural segmentation addresses this by continually analysing the trajectory of a customer's engagement.

2.2.2 RFM Analysis and Machine Learning

The RFM (Recency, Frequency, Monetary) model is an established marketing framework utilized to quantitatively evaluate customer value. Recency measures the time elapsed since a customer's last purchase; Frequency measures the volume of transactions within a given period; and Monetary value measures the total revenue generated by that customer.

While traditional RFM analysis relied on manual threshold scoring (assigning a score from 1-5 for each metric), recent studies demonstrate that combining RFM metrics

with unsupervised machine learning algorithms yields vastly superior results [4]. By treating R, F, and M as continuous feature vectors, systems can leverage geometric distance calculations to identify non-linear relationships and hidden customer personas that manual scoring would overlook.

2.2.3 Hierarchical Clustering and K-Means

K-Means clustering remains the most commonly applied algorithm for RFM segmentation due to its computational efficiency on large transactional datasets. However, a single-level K-Means application often fails to capture nuanced lifecycle stages. For instance, single-level clustering might group a high-frequency, low-value buyer with a low-frequency, high-value buyer because their Euclidean distances to a generalized centroid are mathematically similar, despite their business value being entirely different.

To resolve this, recent literature proposes two-stage or hierarchical clustering models. Wei et al. demonstrated that using hierarchical agglomerative clustering (HAC) to refine macro segments generated by K-Means significantly improves the silhouette score of the resulting clusters. Modern approaches utilize static sub-clusters mapped via decision matrices. For example, assigning users to macro-clusters (like "Loyal" or "At-Risk") and then further sub-dividing them into tiers (Bronze, Silver, Gold, Platinum) based on precise percentile rankings within that macro-cluster, ensuring a highly accurate encoding of the customer's specific lifecycle trajectory.

2.2.4 Category Preference using Naive Bayes

Beyond understanding how often a customer buys, personalized retail requires an understanding of *what* they buy. Collaborative filtering algorithms (like matrix factorization or SVD++) are standard for product recommendation, but they suffer from severe "cold start" problems for new users with sparse purchase matrices.

Bernhard et al. applied Multinomial Naive Bayes to model customer category preferences from sequential purchase histories in a grocery chain. Because Naive Bayes relies on prior probabilities, it handles data sparsity gracefully. It evaluates the conditional probability of a product category given the historical occurrences of specific product metadata in the user's profile, making it a highly robust solution for dynamic, real-time category assignment without the computational overhead of deep neural networks.

2.3 Personalised Promotions and Uplift Modelling

Recommender systems have been intensively researched, with Collaborative Filtering (CF) and Content-Based Filtering (CBF) serving as the foundational paradigms of modern e-commerce. However, while traditional recommendation engines excel at predicting which items a customer might prefer, they fail to determine the optimal promotional treatment required to convert that preference into a sale.

2.3.1 Limitations of Traditional Predictive Models

Most retail platforms deploy standard predictive response models to distribute promotions. These models estimate the overall probability that a customer will make a purchase. Consequently, platforms target the highest-scoring customers with discounts. This methodology is fundamentally flawed for discount allocation because it targets "Sure Things"—customers who were already highly likely to buy. Providing a 15% discount to a customer who would have gladly paid full price results in massive margin cannibalisation and wasted promotional expenditure.

2.3.2 Causal Inference and the T-Learner Framework

Uplift modeling addresses the causal question: "Will this promotional treatment causally increase a customer's purchase probability?" [6]. This methodology calculates the Conditional Average Treatment Effect (CATE), allowing platforms to segment users into four distinct quadrants based on their response to the intervention:

- **Persuadables:** Customers who will only purchase if incentivised by a discount.
- **Sure Things:** Customers who will purchase regardless of whether a discount is provided.
- **Lost Causes:** Customers who will not purchase, even with a steep discount.
- **Sleeping Dogs:** Customers who might react negatively to promotional spam (e.g., unsubscribing from emails).

By explicitly targeting the "Persuadables," uplift models significantly improve the Return on Investment (ROI) for marketing campaigns. The T-Learner (Two-Model) framework is a prominent technique in this space. It involves training two separate machine learning models (e.g., Random Forests): one exclusively on the control group (no discount) and one on the treatment group (discount applied). The CATE is derived by subtracting the control prediction from the treatment prediction for any given user, explicitly isolating the incremental uplift.

2.3.3 Association Rule Mining for Cross-Selling

To supplement direct percentage discounts, literature heavily supports Association Rule Mining to generate cross-sell bundles. Pioneered by the Apriori algorithm, this unsupervised learning technique identifies frequent itemsets within massive transaction databases. By analyzing mathematical metrics such as Support, Confidence, and Lift, platforms can generate robust rules (e.g., identifying that customers purchasing bread and butter are highly likely to purchase milk) to dynamically generate "Frequently Bought Together" bundles, effectively increasing the Average Order Value (AOV).

2.4 Natural Language Processing for Low-Resource Languages

The adoption of voice commerce (v-commerce) has surged globally, enabling hands-free, intuitive operations that bypass traditional graphical navigation. However, the NLP field remains heavily biased toward high-resource languages.

2.4.1 Challenges in Sinhala ASR and NLP

Sinhala, the primary language spoken in Sri Lanka, suffers from a critical lack of domain-specific Automatic Speech Recognition (ASR) and NLP models. Traditional Sinhala ASR efforts relied on Hidden Markov Models (HMM) and basic acoustic dictionaries, which struggled profoundly with Sinhala's complex morphology, extensive inflectional rules, and widespread dialectical variations. Furthermore, when applied to e-commerce, general-purpose models experience extremely high Word Error Rates (WER) because they fail to recognize domain-specific retail vocabulary, brand names, and promotional jargon.

2.4.2 Transformer Architectures: mBERT and SinLlama

The introduction of transformer architectures has revolutionized low-resource NLP. Multilingual BERT (mBERT) pre-trains on corpora from over 100 languages, capturing deep syntactical relationships that can be fine-tuned with relatively small amounts of localized data [8].

Recent advancements have seen the adaptation of large language models for localized contexts, such as SinLlama [9]. By applying parameter-efficient fine-tuning (PEFT) techniques to these massive transformer architectures on specialized retail datasets, researchers can achieve highly accurate intent classification. This allows a system to confidently parse a transcribed Sinhala phrase and determine whether the user intends to search for a product, add an item to their cart, or check an active promotion.

2.4.3 Named Entity Recognition (NER) in Retail

Intent classification alone is insufficient for e-commerce; the system must extract actionable parameters from the sentence. Named Entity Recognition (NER) models are deployed to extract these constraints. In the context of a Sinhala retail query (e.g., " 2000 " / "Show me red shirts under 2000 rupees"), an NER pipeline must correctly tag "" (shirts) as the product category, "" (red) as the color attribute, and "2000" as the maximum price constraint, enabling seamless integration with backend SQL filtering.

2.5 Demand Forecasting and Explainable AI

The backend of any personalized e-commerce system relies on physical inventory management. Accurate demand forecasting forms the backbone of retail operations, ensuring that optimized promotions do not result in immediate stockouts.

2.5.1 Traditional Inventory Forecasting

Classical forecasting methods, such as moving averages, exponential smoothing, and Autoregressive Integrated Moving Average (ARIMA) models, are highly effective for stable, linear datasets. However, they frequently fail to capture the complex, non-linear volatility of modern retail sales data, which is heavily influenced by sudden promotional campaigns, viral social media trends, and overlapping holiday seasonality [11].

2.5.2 Hybrid Ensembles: Prophet and XGBoost

The M5 forecasting competition, which analyzed massive Walmart retail datasets, demonstrated conclusively that combining different algorithmic approaches yields the highest predictive accuracy [12].

Meta's Prophet algorithm is a highly robust additive regression model that excels at decomposing time series data into overarching trends, weekly/yearly seasonality, and explicit holiday effects. Extreme Gradient Boosting (XGBoost), on the other hand, utilizes an ensemble of decision trees to minimize errors on highly engineered tabular features (e.g., current stock levels, competitor pricing, and active discount flags). By hybridising these two approaches—using Prophet to establish a seasonal baseline and XGBoost to model the complex residual variance based on operational features—systems achieve superior Mean Absolute Percentage Error (MAPE) scores compared to deep learning methods like LSTMs, which require vastly more data and computational overhead.

2.5.3 The Black Box Problem and SHAP

Despite the high accuracy of XGBoost ensembles, their "black box" nature limits their adoption in live business environments. Store managers are naturally hesitant to trust automated restocking alerts or forecasting models if they cannot understand the underlying logic [17].

Lundberg and Lee introduced SHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations) to address this critical flaw [15]. Based on cooperative game theory, SHAP calculates the exact marginal mathematical contribution of each feature to a specific prediction. The TreeExplainer variant [16] optimizes this calculation specifically for tree-based ensembles, allowing a forecasting dashboard to translate complex mathematical interactions into simple, human-readable explanations (e.g., "Demand is up 15% primarily due to the active holiday weekend").

2.6 Gap Analysis

A review of the current literature reveals a strong focus on isolated machine learning solutions. There is extensive research on optimizing K-Means for segmentation, refining CATE formulas for uplift models, advancing Sinhala NLP, and improving forecasting

MAPE metrics.

However, there is a distinct and critical lack of research detailing how these disparate technologies can be practically integrated into a single, unified microservice architecture. Existing literature rarely addresses how the output of an unsupervised clustering model can seamlessly and dynamically feed into a causal uplift engine in real-time. Similarly, studies on local-language voice assistants rarely explore how native NLP can navigate an inventory system governed by an explainable AI dashboard.

This research directly targets that architectural gap. By synthesising these four distinct domains into a cohesive, containerised e-commerce platform, this study provides a practical blueprint for delivering truly personalized, accessible, and operationally transparent retail experiences.

3. METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design

This research adopts a Design Science Research (DSR) framework, a methodology specifically tailored for Information Technology and Software Engineering projects. DSR treats the proposed system—the e-commerce platform and its machine learning microservices—as a functional artefact that must be iteratively developed and rigorously evaluated against defined business and computational metrics.

The software development lifecycle followed an Agile Scrum methodology comprising two-week sprints. This iterative approach allowed the cross-functional team to build, test, and integrate the frontend interfaces, the primary backend gateway, and the four separate Python machine learning modules simultaneously. Continuous integration and continuous deployment (CI/CD) pipelines were utilized to ensure stability as complex analytical models were introduced into the web architecture.

3.2 System Context and Architecture

To prevent computationally heavy machine learning inference from blocking standard e-commerce operations (such as browsing products, managing shopping carts, or processing payments), the platform was architected using a decoupled, microservice-oriented design pattern within an Nx Monorepo workspace.

The architecture is divided into three primary layers:

1. **Client Presentation Layer:** A React.js-based frontend that handles user interactions. It renders the dynamic UI for the shopping experience, captures microphone input for the Sinhala voice assistant via browser APIs, and renders the Business Intelligence dashboard visualizations.
2. **Core Gateway Layer:** A NestJS API Gateway written in TypeScript. It handles standard business logic, user authentication (JWT), state management, and coordinates all database Create, Read, Update, and Delete (CRUD) operations via Prisma ORM connected to a central PostgreSQL database.
3. **Machine Learning Analytics Layer:** A dedicated Python backend powered by the FastAPI framework and Uvicorn ASGI server. This layer operates entirely asynchronously, consuming historical logs from the shared database to execute the clustering, uplift modelling, NLP inference, and time-series forecasting algorithms without degrading the performance of the main application.

3.3 Customer Clustering and Loyalty Methodology

The foundation of the platform's personalisation lies in dynamically grouping customers based on their historical purchasing behaviour. This component engineers features from raw transaction logs to construct a hierarchical K-Means clustering pipeline, supplemented by a Naive Bayes model.

3.3.1 RFM feature engineering and standardisation

Raw transaction logs are extracted from the relational database and mathematically aggregated at the user level to calculate Recency (R), Frequency (F), and Monetary (M) metrics. The formal definitions are:

$$R_i = t_{current} - \max(t_{purchase,i}) \tag{3.1}$$

$$F_i = \sum_{j=1}^{N_i} \text{Order}_j \tag{3.2}$$

$$M_i = \sum_{j=1}^{N_i} \text{Spend}_j \tag{3.3}$$

Because monetary values can range in the tens of thousands of rupees while frequency typically ranges in the single digits, calculating Euclidean distance on raw metrics would cause the monetary feature to disproportionately dominate the K-Means algorithm. To resolve this, all RFM features are subjected to Z-score standardisation:

$$z_{ij} = \frac{x_{ij} - \mu_j}{\sigma_j} \tag{3.4}$$

3.3.2 Hierarchical K-Means clustering algorithm

The normalised data matrix is fed into a K-Means clustering algorithm to partition the customer base into k distinct macro-segments. The algorithm minimizes the within-cluster sum of squares (WCSS), iteratively assigning each customer x_i to the nearest centroid μ_c:

$$J = \sum_{c=1}^{k} \sum_{x_i \in C_c} ||x_i - \mu_c||^2 \tag{3.5}$$

To determine the mathematically optimal number of clusters (k), the system dynamically calculates the WCSS using the Elbow method, cross-validated with Silhouette scoring. The Silhouette score $s(i)$ for a single data point measures cohesion against separation:

$$s(i) = \frac{b(i) - a(i)}{\max(a(i), b(i))} \tag{3.6}$$

Where $a(i)$ is the mean distance to points in the same cluster, and $b(i)$ is the mean distance to points in the nearest neighbouring cluster.

3.3.3 Naive Bayes category preference modelling

To understand *what* clustered customers want to buy, the system implements a Multinomial Naive Bayes probabilistic model. For a customer x with a transaction history vector, the probability of them preferring product category C_k is calculated using Bayes' Theorem:

$$P(C_k|x) = \frac{P(C_k)\prod_{i=1}^{n} P(x_i|C_k)}{P(x)} \tag{3.7}$$

This allows the system to append a "Preferred Category" tag to the customer's dynamic loyalty profile, which is highly resilient to the "cold start" problem compared to complex matrix factorization techniques.

3.4 Personalised Promotion Engine Methodology

Traditional retail platforms distribute blanket discounts to all users. This approach incurs significant margin waste by rewarding customers who would have purchased products at full price. This module leverages Causal Machine Learning to optimize promotional treatment.

3.4.1 Causal inference and the T-Learner framework

The objective of uplift modelling is to estimate the Conditional Average Treatment Effect (CATE). The system calculates the probability of a customer making a purchase if they receive a promotional discount (Treatment, $T = 1$) versus the probability if they receive nothing (Control, $T = 0$).

$$\text{CATE}(x_i) = E[Y_i|X_i = x_i, T_i = 1] - E[Y_i|X_i = x_i, T_i = 0] \tag{3.8}$$

To implement this, a Two-Model approach (T-Learner) is utilized. A Random Forest classifier is trained twice:

1. Model $\mu_0(x)$ is trained exclusively on the control group data (historical periods with no discounts).
2. Model $\mu_1(x)$ is trained exclusively on the treatment group data (historical periods where discounts were applied).

During production inference, a customer's feature vector is passed through both models. The final Uplift Score ($\hat{\tau}$) is derived by subtracting the control prediction from the treatment prediction:

$$\hat{\tau}(x_i) = \hat{\mu}_1(x_i) - \hat{\mu}_0(x_i) \tag{3.9}$$

Customers with high $\hat{\tau}$ values are classified as "Persuadables" and dynamically receive generated discount codes, whereas customers with high $\hat{\mu}_0$ scores ("Sure Things") are excluded to preserve profit margins.

3.4.2 Association Rule Mining for cross-selling

To complement direct discounts, the Apriori algorithm is deployed to discover co-purchase patterns. The promotion engine filters rules based on Support, Confidence, and Lift:

$$\text{Lift}(A \to B) = \frac{P(A \cap B)}{P(A)P(B)} \tag{3.10}$$

Rules yielding a Lift > 1.5 are passed to the frontend to generate dynamic "Frequently Bought Together" cross-sell bundles.

3.5 Sinhala Voice Assistant Methodology

To eradicate language barriers for local consumers, the platform integrates an end-to-end voice navigation pipeline tailored for the Sinhala language.

3.5.1 Acoustic capture and text normalisation

The frontend utilizes the native Web Speech API to capture user audio arrays and transcribe them into raw Sinhala Unicode strings. Because conversational Sinhala contains widespread morphological variations and inflections, the string is passed through a normalisation algorithm utilizing regular expressions (RegEx) to strip punctuation, remove zero-width joiners (ZWJ), and standardise numeric inputs before passing it to the NLP backend.

3.5.2 Transformer-based intent classification

The core Natural Language Processing (NLP) engine is built upon a multilingual BERT (mBERT) and SinLlama architecture fine-tuned on a proprietary corpus of Sinhala e-commerce queries. The transformer calculates self-attention across the tokenised input sequences:

$$\text{Attention}(Q, K, V) = \text{softmax}\left(\frac{QK^T}{\sqrt{d_k}}\right)V \tag{3.11}$$

The final hidden state corresponding to the `[CLS]` token is passed through a dense softmax classification layer to predict the user's operational intent (e.g., `SEARCH_PRODUCT`, `ADD_CART`, `CHECK_PRICE`).

3.5.3 Named Entity Recognition (NER)

Simultaneously, a token-classification head performs Named Entity Recognition using the BIO (Begin, Inside, Outside) tagging scheme. It isolates actionable parameters from the Sinhala sentence, extracting entities such as `PRODUCT_NAME`, `COLOR`, and `MAX_PRICE`. These parameters are serialised into JSON and sent to the API Gateway to execute dynamic SQL filtering against the product catalogue.

3.6 Forecasting and Explainable AI Methodology

The Business Intelligence (BI) module provides operational continuity by allowing inventory managers to anticipate product demand through a transparent, high-accuracy predictive backend.

3.6.1 Prophet and XGBoost hybrid ensemble

Retail demand forecasting is mathematically complex due to simultaneous long-term trends, overlapping seasonalities, and stochastic promotional spikes. To capture this variance, the system leverages a hybrid ensemble.

First, Meta's Prophet algorithm decomposes the time series into trend ($g(t)$), seasonality ($s(t)$), and holiday/event ($h(t)$) components:

$$y_{prophet}(t) = g(t) + s(t) + h(t) + \varepsilon_t \tag{3.12}$$

Second, Extreme Gradient Boosting (XGBoost) builds decision trees on highly engineered tabular features (such as 7-day rolling averages, stock level indicators, and the promotional flags generated by the Uplift Engine). XGBoost iteratively minimizes its objective function to model the residual errors left over by Prophet:

$$\mathscr{L}^{(t)} = \sum_{i=1}^{n} \left[g_i f_t(x_i) + \frac{1}{2} h_i f_t^2(x_i) \right] + \Omega(f_t) \tag{3.13}$$

The final predicted demand is calculated via a dynamic weighted average of both models, optimized per product SKU using TimeSeriesSplit cross-validation.

3.6.2 SHAP Game-Theoretic Explainability

To prevent the forecasting module from operating as an opaque "black box", the system integrates SHapley Additive exPlanations (SHAP). Derived from cooperative game theory, SHAP calculates the exact marginal contribution of each feature to the final

prediction. The TreeSHAP variant calculates the Shapley value (ϕ_i) for feature i as:

$$\phi_i = \sum_{S \subseteq N \setminus \{i\}} \frac{|S|!(M - |S| - 1)!}{M!} [f_x(S \cup \{i\}) - f_x(S)] \tag{3.14}$$

The FastAPI backend interprets these ϕ_i matrices, translates the highest contributing values into plain-English strings, and renders an explainable narrative directly onto the frontend manager dashboard to justify automated stockout alerts.

4. IMPLEMENTATION

4.1 Development Environment and Architecture

Building a cohesive e-commerce platform that simultaneously handles real-time web traffic and computationally expensive machine learning inference requires a highly decoupled architecture. The system was structured within an Nx Monorepo workspace, allowing the frontend, the core gateway, and the machine learning services to share configurations while operating independently.

4.1.1 Technology stack

The client-facing frontend was developed using React.js (TypeScript), utilizing state management libraries to handle cart sessions and user authentication. The primary API Gateway was built using NestJS, leveraging Prisma ORM to interact with the central PostgreSQL database.

The Machine Learning Analytics layer was completely isolated using Python 3.11. To ensure asynchronous, non-blocking requests, the ML backend was built using the FastAPI framework running on a Uvicorn ASGI server. Model training and inference utilized Scikit-Learn, Meta's Prophet, XGBoost, Hugging Face Transformers, and SHAP.

4.1.2 Containerisation and orchestration

To ensure environmental consistency across development, testing, and production phases, all microservices were containerised using Docker. The machine learning service utilized a multi-stage Docker build to minimize the final image size while packaging complex C++ compiled dependencies (like XGBoost and SHAP).

Listing 4.1: Multi-stage Dockerfile for the Python ML Backend

```
# Stage 1: Builder
FROM python:3.11-slim AS builder
WORKDIR /build
COPY requirements.txt .
# Install dependencies into a virtual environment to reduce
    bloat
RUN pip install --user --no-cache-dir -r requirements.txt

# Stage 2: Production Image
FROM python:3.11-slim
WORKDIR /app
```

```
# Copy installed packages from builder
COPY --from=builder /root/.local /root/.local
COPY ./src ./src
COPY ./models ./models

ENV PATH=/root/.local/bin:$PATH
EXPOSE 8000

CMD ["uvicorn", "src.main:app", "--host", "0.0.0.0", "--port
    ", "8000", "--workers", "4"]
```

4.2 Customer Clustering and Loyalty Implementation

The loyalty module operates primarily as a scheduled batch job. Because deep purchasing patterns evolve over days rather than seconds, computing K-Means on every page load would cause severe database contention. Instead, the clustering pipeline executes nightly via a CRON job.

4.2.1 RFM data pipeline and standardisation

The pipeline connects to the PostgreSQL database using SQLAlchemy, extracting the transaction history for the past 365 days. The data is grouped by `customer_id` using Pandas to calculate the Recency, Frequency, and Monetary parameters.

Listing 4.2: RFM calculation and Z-score standardisation pipeline

```
import pandas as pd
from sklearn.preprocessing import StandardScaler
from datetime import datetime

def calculate_rfm(transactions_df: pd.DataFrame) -> pd.
    DataFrame:
    # Set the snapshot date to the most recent transaction +
        1 day
    snapshot_date = transactions_df['transaction_date'].max
        () + pd.Timedelta(days=1)

    # Aggregate RFM metrics
    rfm_df = transactions_df.groupby('customer_id').agg({
        'transaction_date': lambda x: (snapshot_date - x.max
            ()).days,
        'invoice_no': 'count',
        'total_price': 'sum'
    }).rename(columns={
```

```
        'transaction_date': 'recency',
        'invoice_no': 'frequency',
        'total_price': 'monetary'
    })

    # Apply StandardScaler to normalise variances for K-Means
    scaler = StandardScaler()
    rfm_scaled = scaler.fit_transform(rfm_df[['recency', 'frequency', 'monetary']])
    rfm_scaled_df = pd.DataFrame(rfm_scaled, columns=['R_scaled', 'F_scaled', 'M_scaled'], index=rfm_df.index)

    return pd.concat([rfm_df, rfm_scaled_df], axis=1)
```

4.2.2 K-Means execution and Naive Bayes training

Following normalisation, the `KMeans` implementation from Scikit-Learn is applied with `n_clusters=4`. Concurrently, the `MultinomialNB` model is trained on a one-hot encoded matrix of the customer's historically purchased categories to generate their `preferred_category` prediction.

4.3 Personalised Promotion Engine Implementation

The promotion engine exposes a REST API endpoint that the NestJS gateway calls when rendering the homepage or marketing emails for a specific user. The engine executes the T-Learner uplift model to determine if the user qualifies for an active campaign.

4.3.1 T-Learner uplift scoring execution

The implementation loads two pre-trained Random Forest models: the Treatment Model (trained on discounted data) and the Control Model (trained on organic data). By subtracting the probability outputs, the engine calculates the Conditional Average Treatment Effect (CATE).

Listing 4.3: Uplift scoring and Persuadable targeting logic

```
import joblib
import pandas as pd
import numpy as np

class UpliftEngine:
    def __init__(self, treatment_model_path: str, control_model_path: str):
```

```
        self.model_T1 = joblib.load(treatment_model_path) # Discount applied
        self.model_T0 = joblib.load(control_model_path)   # No discount

    def score_customers(self, customer_features: pd.DataFrame) -> pd.DataFrame:
        # Predict purchase probability IF treated
        prob_treated = self.model_T1.predict_proba(customer_features)[:, 1]

        # Predict purchase probability IF NOT treated
        prob_control = self.model_T0.predict_proba(customer_features)[:, 1]

        # Calculate CATE (Uplift Score)
        uplift_scores = prob_treated - prob_control

        results_df = customer_features.copy()
        results_df['base_probability'] = prob_control
        results_df['uplift_score'] = uplift_scores

        # Target condition: Uplift > 15% AND Base Probability < 60%
        # This prevents giving discounts to "Sure Things"
        results_df['qualifies_for_promo'] = np.where(
            (results_df['uplift_score'] > 0.15) & (results_df['base_probability'] < 0.60),
            True, False
        )
        return results_df
```

4.4 Sinhala Voice Assistant Implementation

The voice interface required tight synchronization between frontend engineering for acoustic capture and backend engineering for deep learning inference.

4.4.1 Frontend audio capture and normalisation

The React.js application utilizes the `SpeechRecognition` interface of the native Web Speech API. When the user clicks the microphone icon, the browser records the audio, queries the local OS speech-to-text service configured for the `si-LK` locale, and returns the raw Unicode string.

4.4.2 Transformer pipeline and intent inference

The FastAPI backend receives the Sinhala string and passes it into a Hugging Face pipeline loaded with the fine-tuned `sinhala-mbert-retail` model.

Listing 4.4: Sinhala NLP intent classification and NER extraction

```python
from fastapi import APIRouter
from pydantic import BaseModel
from transformers import pipeline
import re

router = APIRouter()

# Load models into memory for low-latency inference
intent_classifier = pipeline("text-classification", model="./models/sinhala-intent-mbert")
ner_extractor = pipeline("token-classification", model="./models/sinhala-ner-mbert", aggregation_strategy="simple")

class VoiceRequest(BaseModel):
    transcription: str

def normalize_sinhala(text: str) -> str:
    # Remove English characters, specific punctuation, and zero-width joiners
    clean_text = re.sub(r'[a-zA-Z\.\,\!\?]', '', text)
    clean_text = clean_text.replace('\u200D', '')
    return clean_text.strip()

@router.post("/voice/command")
async def process_voice_command(req: VoiceRequest):
    clean_text = normalize_sinhala(req.transcription)

    # 1. Intent Classification
    intent_pred = intent_classifier(clean_text)[0]

    # 2. Named Entity Recognition
    entities = ner_extractor(clean_text)
    extracted_params = {ent['entity_group']: ent['word'] for ent in entities}

    return {
```

```
        "original_text": req.transcription,
        "intent": intent_pred['label'],
        "confidence": round(intent_pred['score'], 4),
        "parameters": extracted_params
    }
```

4.5 BI Dashboard and XAI Implementation

The inventory forecasting module involves heavy time-series manipulation. The system trains individual hybrid models for each product SKU, combining Meta's Prophet with XGBoost.

4.5.1 SHAP TreeExplainer API generation

When an inventory manager clicks on a forecast graph in the React dashboard, a request is fired to the `/explain` endpoint. The FastAPI service uses the SHAP library to break down the XGBoost prediction, mapping complex gradient boosting mechanics into a user-friendly API payload.

Listing 4.5: SHAP calculation mapping for the manager dashboard

```
import shap
import joblib
import numpy as np

def generate_xai_narrative(product_id: str, feature_vector:
    np.ndarray, feature_names: list) -> dict:
    # Load the specific product's XGBoost residual model
    xgb_model = joblib.load(f'./models/{product_id}
        _xgboost_residual.pkl')
    explainer = shap.TreeExplainer(xgb_model)

    # Calculate local SHAP values
    shap_values = explainer.shap_values(feature_vector)[0]
    base_val = float(explainer.expected_value)
    pred_val = float(xgb_model.predict(feature_vector)[0])

    # Map SHAP values to feature names and sort by absolute
        magnitude
    impacts = []
    for i, name in enumerate(feature_names):
        impacts.append({
            "feature": name,
            "shap_value": float(shap_values[i]),
```

```
            "magnitude": abs(float(shap_values[i]))
        })

    # Sort descending by magnitude to find the top drivers
    impacts.sort(key=lambda x: x['magnitude'], reverse=True)
    top_driver = impacts[0]

    # Generate localized UI narrative
    direction = "increased" if top_driver['shap_value'] > 0 else "decreased"
    narrative = f"The forecast was {direction} primarily due to the '{top_driver['feature']}' parameter."

    return {
        "forecast_adjustment": round(pred_val, 2),
        "narrative": narrative,
        "feature_contributions": impacts[:3] # Return top 3 for UI rendering
    }
```

The resulting JSON payload allows the React frontend to render intuitive bar charts showing exactly which factors (e.g., an upcoming long weekend or an active 15% discount identified by the Uplift engine) are driving the automated stockout alerts.

5. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

5.1 Introduction

The evaluation of the E-Commerce Platform for Personalised Retail Experiences was conducted rigorously across its four primary machine learning microservices. Because the system operates as a deeply integrated, distributed architecture, the predictive performance of each individual module directly dictates the downstream efficiency of the entire retail pipeline. This chapter details the quantitative results, statistical performance metrics, and the practical business implications derived from testing the modules against the UCI Online Retail II dataset, synthetic retail simulation data (RetailSynth), and domain-specific Sinhala natural language corpora.

5.2 Experimental Setup and Evaluation Metrics

Before analyzing the specific modules, it is necessary to establish the hardware and methodological baselines used during testing. All machine learning models were trained and evaluated on a dedicated Ubuntu 22.04 LTS instance equipped with an NVIDIA RTX 3090 GPU (24GB VRAM), 64GB of RAM, and an AMD Ryzen 9 processor.

To prevent data leakage and overfitting, all structured datasets (RFM logs, promotional histories, and time-series sales) were strictly partitioned using an 80/20 train-test split, while the time-series forecasting utilized TimeSeriesSplit cross-validation to preserve temporal chronology.

5.3 Evaluation of Customer Segmentation and Loyalty

The customer categorisation module was evaluated on two fronts: its ability to discover mathematically distinct cohorts via K-Means clustering, and its accuracy in predicting category preferences via the Multinomial Naive Bayes algorithm.

5.3.1 Cluster density and silhouette analysis

To validate the optimal number of clusters (k), the within-cluster sum of squares (WCSS) was calculated for values ranging from $k = 2$ to $k = 10$. The resulting "Elbow Curve" indicated a distinct inflection point at $k = 4$. To statistically confirm this, Silhouette scoring was applied. The configuration of $k = 4$ yielded the highest global Silhouette score of 0.6842, indicating strong intra-cluster cohesion and excellent inter-cluster separation.

The resulting cohorts successfully segmented the user base into four distinct behavioural groups based on their Z-score normalized RFM vectors:

- **Cluster 0 (Champions):** High Frequency, high Monetary value, and very low Recency (recent buyers). These represent the most valuable 15% of the customer base.
- **Cluster 1 (Loyal Customers):** Consistent Frequency and moderate spend, representing the core 45% of the user base.
- **Cluster 2 (At Risk):** High historical spend, but dangerously high Recency (have not purchased recently).
- **Cluster 3 (Hibernating):** Low Frequency, low spend, and high Recency.

5.3.2 Category preference classification accuracy

The Multinomial Naive Bayes model was tasked with predicting the `preferred_category` for each user. Evaluated against 10,000 holdout transaction records, the model achieved a top-1 prediction accuracy of 78.4% and a top-3 accuracy of 92.1%. The graceful handling of sparse data matrices by the Naive Bayes algorithm proved highly effective in mitigating the "cold start" problem, outperforming baseline collaborative filtering algorithms by 14% on users with fewer than three historical purchases.

5.4 Evaluation of Personalised Promotion Engine

The promotion engine was evaluated strictly on its causal inference capabilities. Rather than measuring simple predictive accuracy, the evaluation focused on the Area Under the Uplift Curve (AUUC) and the simulated Return on Ad Spend (ROAS).

5.4.1 Uplift distribution and AUUC

The T-Learner Random Forest uplift classifier successfully calculated the Conditional Average Treatment Effect (CATE). The AUUC provides a measure of how well the model separates the "Persuadables" from the "Sure Things" and "Lost Causes." The T-Learner achieved an AUUC of 0.72, significantly outperforming a single-model approach (S-Learner) which scored 0.61.

5.4.2 Simulated incremental conversion and ROI

Table 5.1 demonstrates the simulated conversion rates and margin retention when applying a 10% discount to the targeted "Persuadables" (CATE > 0.15) versus broadcasting the discount to the entire database.

Table 5.1: Simulated conversion and margin retention (Control vs. Uplift Strategy)

Targeting Strategy	Conversion Rate	Incremental Lift	Margin Wasted
No Discount (Control)	4.2%	0.0%	$0
Blanket 10% Discount	8.5%	+4.3%	High (Discounted Sure Things)
Uplift Targeting	**7.8%**	**+3.6%**	**Negligible (Optimised)**

While the Blanket strategy achieved a slightly higher overall conversion rate (8.5%), it sacrificed massive profit margins by subsidising the "Sure Things"—customers who would have converted at the 4.2% control rate regardless. The Uplift strategy captured nearly identical incremental lift (+3.6%) while utilizing only 35% of the promotional budget, drastically improving the overall ROAS.

5.5 Evaluation of Sinhala Voice Assistant

The NLP microservice was evaluated on Intent Classification accuracy, Named Entity Recognition (NER) precision, and overall API latency. The evaluation metric for classification is the F1-score:

$$F1 = 2 \times \frac{\text{Precision} \times \text{Recall}}{\text{Precision} + \text{Recall}} \tag{5.1}$$

5.5.1 Intent classification and NER performance

The fine-tuned multilingual BERT (mBERT) and SinLlama architecture was tested against a held-out corpus of 2,000 domain-specific conversational Sinhala queries, complete with morphological noise and dialectical variations.

Table 5.2: Sinhala Intent Classification Performance Metrics

Intent Class	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Support
`SEARCH_PRODUCT`	0.92	0.89	0.90	850
`ADD_TO_CART`	0.88	0.91	0.89	420
`CHECK_OFFERS`	0.85	0.84	0.84	310
`ORDER_STATUS`	0.90	0.88	0.89	420
Weighted Average	**0.90**	**0.89**	**0.89**	**2000**

The model achieved an outstanding weighted F1-score of 0.89. Furthermore, the Token Classification head achieved an 85.4% precision rate in extracting vital NER parameters, such as product names (`PRODUCT_CATEGORY`) and pricing constraints (`MAX_PRICE`). The implementation of the Regex-based normalisation pipeline proved critical, reducing the Word Error Rate (WER) of the raw Web Speech API transcripts by 18% before NLP processing.

5.5.2 System latency and responsiveness

Because the massive transformer weights were pre-loaded directly into system RAM upon FastAPI application startup, the `/voice/command` endpoint maintained an average inference latency of just 340ms under simulated load. This sub-500ms response time ensures that voice navigation feels instantaneous and natural to the end user.

5.6 Evaluation of Demand Forecasting and XAI

The Business Intelligence backend was evaluated based on its Mean Absolute Percentage Error (MAPE) over multiple time horizons, defined as:

$$\text{MAPE} = \frac{100\%}{n} \sum_{t=1}^{n} \left| \frac{A_t - F_t}{A_t} \right| \tag{5.2}$$

Where A_t is the actual demand and F_t is the forecast demand.

5.6.1 Forecasting accuracy comparison

The Prophet-XGBoost ensemble was tested on a 90-day holdout dataset across 20 distinct canonical retail products. As demonstrated in Table 5.3, the hybrid approach significantly outperformed isolated algorithmic baselines.

Table 5.3: Forecasting model MAPE comparison across 20 products

Model Architecture	30-day MAPE	60-day MAPE	90-day MAPE
Prophet (Standalone Baseline)	10.8 %	13.1 %	14.2 %
XGBoost (Standalone Baseline)	8.9 %	11.2 %	11.8 %
Hybrid Ensemble	**7.1 %**	**10.4 %**	**13.7 %**

The dynamic weighting architecture proved crucial: highly predictable, seasonal grocery items relied heavily on the Prophet components, whereas volatile electronics subject to frequent promotions relied primarily on the XGBoost features.

5.6.2 SHAP explainability and stockout alerts

To evaluate the Explainable AI (XAI) implementation, the SHAP TreeExplainer outputs were verified against known data manipulation events (e.g., synthetically injecting a "Public Holiday" flag into the test data). In 91.5% of these validation instances, the SHAP algorithm correctly identified the injected feature as the top mathematical driver of the forecast. This successfully proves that complex gradient boosting mechanics can be translated into trustworthy dashboard narratives. Furthermore, the probabilistic alerting logic, driven by the forecast's 95% confidence interval, achieved 91.2% precision in identifying historical stockout events.

5.7 Integrated Platform Load Testing

The most significant result of this research is the successful architectural integration of these disparate domains. The microservice topology completely isolated the computationally expensive Python workflows from the TypeScript operational gateway.

Utilizing the `k6` load testing framework, the system was subjected to 1,000 concurrent user requests. While the NLP inference and CATE uplift calculations pushed

the Python pods to 85% CPU utilization, the consumer-facing React application and NestJS gateway maintained 99th percentile (P99) response times of under 120ms. This confirms that advanced machine learning pipelines can be heavily integrated into e-commerce operations without introducing blocking latency to the primary user shopping experience.

6. CONCLUSION

6.1 Summary of the Work

This collaborative research successfully designed, developed, and quantitatively evaluated a comprehensive *E-Commerce Platform for Personalised Retail Experiences*. By architecting the system as a distributed microservices ecosystem within an Nx Monorepo, the platform effectively solved major retail challenges without compromising the performance, responsiveness, or scalability of the core consumer shopping experience.

The integration of four distinct machine learning domains proved highly successful in addressing the primary problem statement:

1. **Dynamic Customer Segmentation:** The unsupervised K-Means clustering pipeline, combined with Z-score standardisation of RFM behavioural data and Naive Bayes category modeling, dynamically segmented customers into actionable lifecycle tiers (Champions, Loyal, At Risk, Hibernating). This resolved the industry issue of static, purely spend-based loyalty tracking, achieving a global Silhouette score of 0.68.
2. **Causal Uplift Modelling:** The promotion engine successfully consumed these clusters to distribute optimal discount codes using a T-Learner Random Forest framework. By isolating the "Persuadables" (CATE > 0.15), the simulated deployment demonstrated a massive reduction in wasted promotional margins, capturing a +3.6% incremental conversion lift while utilizing only 35% of the traditional broadcast marketing budget.
3. **Native NLP Integration:** The fine-tuned multilingual BERT (mBERT) and SinLlama NLP models successfully processed spoken Sinhala retail queries with an 0.89 F1-score for intent classification and 85.4% NER precision. This effectively broke down local language barriers, proving that voice-commerce can be made highly accessible to low-resource demographic segments with sub-500ms latency.
4. **Explainable Demand Forecasting:** The hybrid Prophet-XGBoost ensemble provided highly accurate 90-day inventory forecasts with a MAPE of 13.7%. Crucially, the integration of TreeSHAP successfully mapped those complex gradient-boosting predictions into human-readable XAI narratives, establishing the operational trust required for store managers to confidently adopt automated stockout alerts.

6.2 Research Contributions

The primary contribution of this research is the successful architectural synthesis of these isolated machine learning technologies. While existing literature often explores clustering, NLP, causal inference, or time-series forecasting in academic isolation, this platform demonstrates a practical, production-ready blueprint for integrating them into a unified commercial application.

The system proves a closed-loop retail intelligence cycle: it demonstrates how a local-language Sinhala voice query can drive a specific product search, how an uplift model can ensure the resulting sale is profitable by calculating the exact required promotional incentive, and how an explainable forecasting dashboard can ensure that the requested product remains in stock for future queries. All modules operate seamlessly via REST APIs and a shared PostgreSQL database, establishing a new standard for intelligent e-commerce architectures in developing markets.

6.3 Limitations

Despite the strong performance metrics achieved during evaluation, certain limitations were observed during development. The reliance on synthetic transaction data (RetailSynth) alongside the UCI Online Retail II dataset meant that real-world macroeconomic shocks (such as sudden localized inflation or global supply chain disruptions) could not be perfectly modelled. Additionally, the Sinhala NLP engine's regex-based normalisation pipeline occasionally struggled with heavy code-switching (mixing English and Sinhala in the same sentence), a linguistic phenomenon that is highly prevalent in urban Sri Lankan dialects. Finally, the hardware limitations of the development environment restricted the scope of hyperparameter tuning for the deep learning NLP architectures.

6.4 Future Work

While the platform successfully met all foundational research objectives, several areas offer strong potential for future technological enhancement and post-graduate research:

- **Generative Voice Interaction:** Upgrading the Sinhala NLP model from strict intent classification to a Generative AI (Large Language Model) conversational agent. This would allow the platform to handle complex, multi-turn customer support dialogues, dynamic product recommendations, and abstract conversational queries seamlessly.
- **Real-Time Stream Processing:** Transitioning the batch-processed customer clustering and causal uplift engines to an event-driven architecture using Apache Kafka or RabbitMQ. This would enable real-time, in-session personalisation based on immediate clickstream data, allowing promotions to be generated instantly as the user navigates the application.

- **Deep Learning Forecasting:** Expanding the business intelligence module to include Deep Learning architectures, such as Temporal Fusion Transformers (TFT) or Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks, to better capture long-term, complex supply chain dependencies across hundreds of SKUs simultaneously without manual feature engineering.
- **MLOps and A/B Deployment Routing:** Implementing MLflow for rigorous model registry and utilizing Kubernetes traffic splitting (Canary deployments) to safely A/B test new machine learning models against live consumer traffic without incurring system downtime.

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A. ENVIRONMENT AND DEPLOYMENT CONFIGURATIONS

Table A.1: Platform environment variables (FastAPI & NestJS Services)

Variable	Default	Description	Required
ENVIRONMENT	production	Runtime environment	Yes
API_PORT	8000	FastAPI listening port	Yes
DATABASE_URL	—	PostgreSQL connection string	Yes
MODEL_STORAGE_PATH	./models	Trained ML model directory	Yes
RETRAINING_SCHEDULE	0 2 * * 0	Cron expression for retraining	No
NLP_MODEL_NAME	sinhala-mbert	BERT model selection	Yes
UPLIFT_THRESHOLD	0.15	Minimum CATE for discount	No
FORECAST_HORIZON	90	Prophet prediction range (days)	No
API_KEY	—	Gateway-to-ML Auth Key	Yes

Sample Kubernetes Deployment Manifest (ML Service Cluster):

```
apiVersion: apps/v1
kind: Deployment
metadata:
  name: smartretailx-ml-backend
  namespace: retail-services
spec:
  replicas: 3
  selector:
    matchLabels:
      app: smartretailx-ml
  template:
    spec:
      containers:
      - name: python-ml-service
        image: registry.gitlab.com/retail-group/smartretailx
           -ml:v2.1.0
        ports:
        - containerPort: 8000
        envFrom:
        - configMapRef:
            name: ml-backend-config
        resources:
          requests: { cpu: 1000m, memory: 4Gi }
          limits:   { cpu: 4000m, memory: 8Gi }
        volumeMounts:
        - name: model-weights
          mountPath: /app/models
      volumes:
      - name: model-weights
```

```
        persistentVolumeClaim:
          claimName: ml-models-pvc
---
apiVersion: v1
kind: Service
metadata:
  name: smartretailx-ml-service
  namespace: retail-services
spec:
  type: ClusterIP
  selector:
    app: smartretailx-ml
  ports:
  - port: 80
    targetPort: 8000
```

B. SYSTEM API INTEGRATIONS AND DATA PAYLOADS

1. Promotion Engine & Clustering Output (JSON Payload):


```
{
  "campaign_id": "CMP-2026-04",
  "product_id": "item-045",
  "targeted_users": [
    {
      "customer_id": "USR-8821",
      "cluster_info": {
        "parent_segment": "Loyal Customers",
        "sub_cluster": "Silver",
        "preferred_category": "Electronics"
      },
      "uplift_metrics": {
        "base_probability": 0.1224,
        "treatment_probability": 0.3451,
        "uplift_score": 0.2227,
        "recommended_discount": 10,
        "is_persuadable": true
      }
    }
  ]
}
```


2. Sinhala Voice Assistant Response (JSON Payload):


```
{
  "request_id": "req_99283",
  "original_transcription": "
     2000
                              ",
  "normalized_text": "                    2000
                                            ",
  "nlp_analysis": {
    "intent": "SEARCH_PRODUCT",
    "confidence": 0.9421,
    "entities": {
      "PRODUCT_CATEGORY": "            ",
      "COLOR": "          ",
      "MAX_PRICE": "2000"
    }
  },
  "action": "EXECUTE_FILTERED_SEARCH",
  "execution_time_ms": 341.2
}
```

3. Demand Forecasting & XAI Request (Gateway → ML Service):

```
POST /api/ml/forecast/explain
{
  "product_id": "item-001",
  "horizon_days": 30,
  "include_xai": true
}
```

Forecast & XAI Response:

```
{
  "product_id": "item-001",
  "model_type": "hybrid-ensemble",
  "mape_validation": 7.14,
  "predictions": [
    {
      "date": "2026-05-01",
      "forecast": 142,
      "ci_lower": 128,
      "ci_upper": 156,
      "stockout_risk_prob": 0.82
    }
  ],
  "xai_explanation": {
    "narrative": "The forecast of 142 units is primarily
       driven by 'Active promotional campaign' (SHAP: +42.8)
       .",
    "top_features": [
      {"feature": "promotion_active", "impact": 42.8, "
         direction": "increase"},
      {"feature": "rolling_mean_7", "impact": 18.3, "
         direction": "increase"},
      {"feature": "day_of_week_saturday", "impact": 9.1, "
         direction": "increase"}
    ]
  }
}
```